



# The Mindful Bloom Journal

*For Restrictive Eating & Anorexia Recovery*

A guided journal of education, coping tools, and reflection





## Welcome

This journal was created to sit alongside your recovery from restrictive eating or anorexia — part workbook, part quiet space to think on paper. Each section pairs a short piece of education with tools you can actually use in the moment, and prompts for noticing the emotions and situations that shape your relationship with food.

There is no correct way to fill these pages. Skip what doesn't fit, return to what helps, and write in whatever order your week calls for.

**Before you begin:** This journal is an educational and reflective companion — it is not therapy, medical care, or a substitute for treatment. It won't include meal plans, calorie or weight numbers, or exercise targets — those belong with your dietitian and medical team, who can account for your specific medical needs. This journal focuses on the thoughts, emotions, and situations underneath the restriction. Please use it alongside support from a doctor, therapist, and/or registered dietitian who knows your full history. If you notice this journal bringing up distress rather than relief, that's worth mentioning to your care team, not pushing through alone.

## How this journal is organized

- **Understanding the pattern** — brief, plain-language education
- **Your toolbox** — coping skills to practice before you need them
- **Daily check-ins** — short, repeatable pages for ongoing use
- **Weekly reflection** — a wider-lens look at the week
- **Values & resources** — what you're working toward, and where to find support





## Understanding the Pattern

*A little education can take the shame out of a very common experience.*

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Anorexia and other restrictive eating patterns are recognized, treatable conditions with serious medical dimensions — they are not a lifestyle choice or simply "willpower." Family-based treatment, CBT-E (enhanced cognitive behavioral therapy), and close medical monitoring are among the most evidence-based approaches, and recovery is genuinely possible at every stage of illness.

### What restriction often does psychologically

- Offers a sense of control when other parts of life feel unpredictable
- Can numb or organize difficult emotions around a rigid, predictable rule
- May feel tied to identity, achievement, or a sense of "discipline" or safety
- Often gets reinforced early by comments, praise, or relief that quietly rewards it

Naming what restriction is doing for you emotionally — separate from what it's costing you physically — is often the turning point that makes recovery motivation more durable than willpower alone.

### Common triggers to watch for

- Situations that feel out of your control
- Comments about bodies, food, or weight — your own or others'
- Anxiety, perfectionism, or a strong urge to "earn" food or rest
- Comparing yourself to others, including on social media
- Transitions: a new season, schedule change, or big life event





# Your Toolbox

*Skills to practice on an ordinary day, so they're ready on a hard one.*

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## Eating with Presence

*A way of sitting with a meal that builds trust with food again — practice this on purpose, not just when a meal feels hard.*

1. Sit down fully with your meal or snack. Put away the phone, step away from the screen — let this be the one thing you're doing.
2. Take three slow breaths before you start, to arrive in the moment instead of planning around the meal.
3. Notice one thing about how the food looks, smells, or feels. No food is "good" or "bad" — it's simply food.
4. Follow the meal or snack as planned with your team, even if part of you wants to stop early, eat less, or skip it. Let the plan carry you rather than the urge.
5. Eat at a comfortable, unhurried pace, pausing now and then to actually notice the taste and texture of what you're eating.
6. When a critical, fearful, or bargaining thought shows up ("I've had enough," "I'll make up for this later"), silently notice it — "there's that thought" — and let it pass without obeying it. You can always write it down afterward instead.
7. After eating, resist the urge to immediately body-check or plan compensation. Choose one grounding action instead — a stretch, a short walk, texting a support person — and remind yourself: this meal is one part of nourishing the life you're rebuilding, not a decision that has to be perfect.

## Opposite action (DBT)

When the urge is to skip or delay eating, opposite action means gently doing the reverse: following your planned meal or snack time as agreed with your care team, even when the urge says not to. The goal isn't to fight the feeling directly, but to not let the feeling drive the behavior.

## Urge surfing

The urge to restrict, like any urge, tends to rise and eventually fall, whether or not you act on it. Try noticing where it shows up in your body and staying curious about it for a few minutes, rather than either obeying it or trying to force it away.

## Widening the sense of control

Because restriction often stands in for a need for control, it can help to actively name other places you do have agency today — a choice of activity, how you spend an hour, a conversation, a creative project. The more those outlets are alive, the less food has to carry that whole job.

## Body-check pause

Mirror checking, pinching, or comparing can spike distress and reinforce restriction. When you notice the urge to check, try pausing for a slow count of ten, naming the emotion you were actually feeling right before the



urge, and choosing one grounding action instead (hands under cold water, stepping outside, texting a support person).

### **5-4-3-2-1 grounding**

Name 5 things you can see, 4 you can hear, 3 you can touch, 2 you can smell, and 1 you can taste. Useful any time anxiety around eating or your body pulls you out of the present moment.

### **Self-compassion break**

Try three lines, in your own words: "This is a moment of struggle. I'm not the only person who has felt this way about food or my body. May I be kind to myself right now." Self-criticism tends to feed the very rules that keep restriction going.





## Thought record (CBT)

Use this any time a thought about food, eating, or your body feels loud or absolute ("I don't deserve this," "I'll lose control if I eat"). Writing it down creates distance from it.

**Situation**

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**Automatic thought**

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**Emotion & intensity (0–10)**

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**Evidence for / against the thought**

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**A more balanced thought**

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## SEEDS balance check

Sleep, Eating (following your planned meals/snacks), Exercise (as agreed with your team — rest counts too), Downtime, Socializing. When one of these is badly out of balance, urges to restrict or over-control tend to intensify. Circle the one most out of balance this week, and name one small way to tend to it.

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## Daily Check-In

*A short page for an ordinary day — use as many copies as you like.*

Date

Did I follow my planned meals/snacks today? What made it easier or harder?

What emotion showed up around food or my body today, and what was happening just before it?

Where did I notice an urge to restrict, control, or check my body — and what tool did I reach for (or could I try next time)?

One thing I want to acknowledge myself for today, unrelated to food or body:





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## Weekly Reflection

*Zoom out from single days to notice the wider pattern.*

**What situations made control or restriction feel most tempting this week?**

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**Which tool from my toolbox did I actually reach for — and how did it go?**

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**Where did I notice fear or guilt around eating? What would I say to a friend feeling that?**

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**What's one pattern I'm starting to notice about my triggers?**

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**What's one small thing I want to try differently next week?**

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## Values & Motivation

Recovery is easier to keep choosing when it's anchored to something bigger than any single meal or moment. Use this page to reconnect with your "why."

**Beyond food, weight, and control, what kind of life am I working toward?**

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**What has this illness taken from me that I'd like back — relationships, energy, spontaneity?**

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**Who or what motivates me to keep going, even on hard days?**

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**What would it feel like to trust my body again, even a little?**

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## Support & Resources

Recovery isn't meant to happen in isolation. Keep this page bookmarked.

**National Alliance for Eating Disorders Helpline** Free, professionally-staffed support and referrals to treatment

**988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline**

Call or text 988 (US) for 24/7 crisis support

**Crisis Text Line**

Text HOME to 741741 (US/Canada) for 24/7 text support

**Your treatment team**

Doctor, therapist, and/or registered dietitian — write their contact info below

### My care team

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### A closing thought

*Healing rarely moves in a straight line, and a hard day with food is information, not a verdict on your worth or your progress. Be as gentle with yourself on the page as you'd be with someone you love.*

